

2024 HYUNDAI SANTA CRUZ SEL

Complete Research Report — CarMax Listing #70137769

THE SPECIFIC VEHICLE

Year / Make / Model:	2024 Hyundai Santa Cruz SEL
Mileage:	~10,000 miles
Price:	\$28,998 (plus \$899 shipping)
Exterior:	Green
Interior:	Gray
Drivetrain:	All-Wheel Drive (AWD)
Engine:	2.5L inline-4, 191 hp / 181 lb-ft
Transmission:	8-speed automatic
Towing Capacity:	3,500 lbs
Bed:	4.0 ft length, 27 cu ft volume
Fuel Economy:	21 city / 25 highway mpg
Warranty:	Remaining 5yr/60k basic, 10yr/100k powertrain
Source:	CarMax Kenner, LA
Return Policy:	10-day money-back guarantee

PRICE REALITY CHECK

Kelley Blue Book Fair Purchase Price for a used 2024 Santa Cruz SEL: **\$22,400**. CarMax is asking **\$28,998** — roughly **\$6,600 above** KBB fair market value. Even with only 10,000 miles, that's a steep premium. You are paying for the no-haggle convenience, the 10-day return window, and the CarMax condition standard. Whether that premium is worth it depends on your risk tolerance.

OWNER SATISFACTION RATINGS

Source	Overall	Recommend
Kelley Blue Book	4.5 / 5 (40 reviews)	88%

Cars.com	4.6 / 5 (11 reviews)	90%
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KBB Owner Breakdown:

Reliability	4.7 / 5
Styling	4.7 / 5
Comfort	4.6 / 5
Performance	4.4 / 5
Quality	4.4 / 5
Value	4.3 / 5

Short version: owners love it. Most common praise: comfortable ride, unique styling, versatile for light hauling, and drives like a compact SUV. Most common complaint: the retractable tonneau cover leaks.

RELIABILITY & LONG-TERM COST

KBB 5-year cost to own estimate: **\$47,112**

- Depreciation: \$15,166
- Maintenance (5yr): ~\$6,378
- Repairs (5yr): ~\$667
- Insurance (5yr): ~\$10,880

Reliability verdict from owners: above average for the class. The powertrain warranty is best-in-class, and the shared Hyundai Tucson platform means parts and mechanical knowledge are widely available.

Reported Problem Patterns:

- Retractable tonneau cover prone to leaking (multiple owner complaints)
- One turbo-model owner reported transmission shifting issues — does *not* apply to this base engine
- A few isolated dealership service complaints, not vehicle defects

RECALLS

There is **one active recall** for the 2024 Santa Cruz:

NHTSA Campaign #24V412000 (issued May 2024)

Component: Electric power steering motor

Issue: Circuit board may short circuit, causing sudden loss of power steering assist

Fix: Dealer replaces the power steering electric power pack — **free of charge**

Action item: Verify this recall has been completed on the specific VIN before purchase.

SAFETY

- IIHS: Top "Good" rating in every crashworthiness category
- NHTSA: 5-star frontal crash, 5-star side crash, 4-star rollover
- Standard safety tech: automatic emergency braking, lane-keep assist, blind-spot monitoring, rear cross-traffic alert, safe exit warning, driver attention warning

WHAT THIS VEHICLE ACTUALLY IS

The Santa Cruz is a unibody "sport adventure vehicle" built on the Hyundai Tucson platform. It is *not* a body-on-frame truck. It will not off-road like a Tacoma, and it will not tow like an F-150.

What it *will* do: haul bikes, kayaks, mulch, furniture, dogs, and weekend gear while driving like a normal compact crossover. If your son wants a 'real truck,' this is not it. If he wants a daily driver that can do light truck things without the truck headaches, this fits.

ENGINE NOTE

This specific vehicle has the base 2.5L engine (191 hp). Reviews agree it is adequate for daily driving but feels strained with a full load or when towing. The optional 2.5L turbo (281 hp) is what most reviewers and owners recommend. If your son has not test-driven both, it is worth the comparison before settling on the base engine.

A HEADS-UP ON FUTURE AVAILABILITY

Multiple reports, including KBB, indicate Hyundai plans to discontinue the Santa Cruz after the 2026 model year in favor of a larger midsize pickup. This could affect long-term parts availability and resale value, though the shared Tucson platform mitigates much of that risk.

BOTTOM LINE

The vehicle itself is well-regarded, safe, and mechanically sound for what it is. The CarMax asking price is steep relative to market value. Recommended steps before committing:

1. Confirm the power steering recall has been completed on this VIN
2. Compare against local dealer used inventory for similar SEL trim Santa Cruz units
3. Test-drive a Santa Cruz with the turbo engine for comparison
4. Factor in the \$899 shipping cost when comparing total out-the-door pricing

SOURCES

- CarMax Listing — [carmax.com/car/70137769](https://www.carmax.com/car/70137769)
- Kelley Blue Book Used Pricing & Reviews — [kbb.com/hyundai/santa-cruz/2024/sel/](https://www.kbb.com/hyundai/santa-cruz/2024/sel/)
- Cars.com Consumer Reviews
- NHTSA Recall Database — [nhtsa.gov/recalls](https://www.nhtsa.gov/recalls) (Campaign 24V412000)